

Σεκούνδος ὁ Σιωπηλός

Silence and the Cynic Life of Secundus

eul_aid: pzk

Period: Ῥωμαϊκή [Roman](#)
Dialect: Κοινή [Koine](#)
Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)
Format: Πεζός [Prose](#)
Affiliation: [Cynic](#)

Secundus the Silent was a Cynic philosopher who lived in the 2nd century CE during the reign of the Roman emperor Hadrian. He is famous for taking a lifelong vow of silence. According to the legend of his life, this vow resulted from a tragic personal test. After disguising himself to proposition his own mother, and her agreeing, he revealed his identity. This caused her such shame that she took her own life. In remorse, Secundus resolved never to speak again.

His reputation for silence eventually led Emperor Hadrian to summon him. The emperor, unable to make Secundus speak even under threat of death, instead engaged him through written questions. This encounter produced the work for which Secundus is known, **Secundus the Silent Philosopher**. The text combines the story of his life with twenty short, aphoristic answers to Hadrian's philosophical questions on topics like the universe, God, and death. According to modern scholars, the legend presents Secundus as a model of Cynic integrity, demonstrating steadfastness and moral courage through silence in the face of power.

A second work, a Greek translation of the fables of Phaedrus, is sometimes attributed to him, but this attribution is generally considered spurious by academics. Secundus's primary text became a popular ethical work in antiquity and was translated into several languages, including Syriac, Armenian, and Arabic. Its wide dissemination into the Middle Ages highlights the enduring appeal of the silent sage as a figure of popular philosophy.

Works (2)

- [Βίος Σεκούνδου](#) · [Life of Secundus](#) · 6 passages
- [Γνώμαι](#) · [Sentences](#) · 11 passages

Other Cynic Authors

- [Ἀντισθένης ὁ Ἀθηναῖος](#) · [Antisthenes of Athens I](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀντισθένης ὁ Ἀθηναῖος](#) · [Antisthenes of Athens II](#) · 2 works
- [Βίων ὁ Βορυσθενίτης](#) · [Bion of Borysthenes](#) · 2 works
- [Κράτης ὁ Θεβαῖος](#) · [Crates of Thebes I](#) · 1 work
- [Δημόναξ ὁ Κύπριος](#) · [Demonax of Cyprus](#) · 1 work
- [Διογένης ὁ Σινωπεύς](#) · [Diogenes of Sinope](#) · 1 work
- [Διοτογένης ὁ φιλόσοφος](#) · [Diotogenes the Philosopher](#) · 1 work

- [Μόνιμος ὁ Συρακόσιος · Monimus of Syracuse](#) · 1 work
- [Οἰνόμαος ὁ Γαδαρεύς · Oenomaus of Gadara](#) · 1 work
- [Τέλης ὁ Μεγαρεύς · Teles of Megara](#) · 8 works